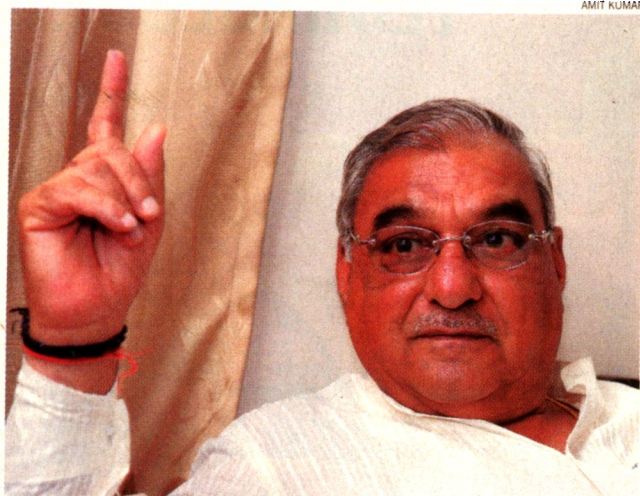


AMIT KUMAR



Damage Control

CHANDIGARH Call it a populist itch or the politics of land, but Haryana Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda has broken a new ground to deflate his opponents' tirade against the special economic zone (SEZ) of Reliance Industries Limited near Gurgaon.

Under fire for transferring 1,300 acres of government-acquired land to the mega SEZ, Hooda has announced an annual royalty of Rs 10,000 per acre for 33 years to farmers affected by the land

acquisition by the state industrial and housing department besides the usual compensation. For good measure, the bonanza, essentially meant to please the restive peasantry, will be applicable with retrospective effect from March 2005 when the Congress came to power.

The chief minister has also announced 25 per cent reservation in Government jobs for farmers and landless villagers dependent on the land

LANDED: Hooda is offering compensation to farmers

acquired for various projects in the state.

As an additional sop for Jats and Dalits, Hooda—half way through his term as chief minister and in need to consolidate his votebank—has offered 9,000 jobs for Dalits as safai karamcharis in the SEZ and land compensation for Jats. He has also announced the construction of a 50-bed hospital and a canal in Gohana near Sonapat, where caste tension surfaced again on August 28 after a Dalit youth was shot dead by unidentified people believed to be from the upper caste.

"It's a landmark decision to protect the interests of farmers," he proclaims. In reality, however, his pro-farmer stance is aimed at blunting the pincer attack by his rebel Congress MP Kuldip Bishnoi and the Opposition over the SEZ project which has also become a sore point with the volatile peasantry across the state.

by Ramesh Vinayak

Art Craft

DELHI A year after it was published in July 2006, INDIA TODAY got the Award for Excellence in Design and Layout in Asia, for its third 30th anniversary issue, in Kuala Lumpur last month. Organised by the Asian Publishing Management Awards, the competition saw 79 entries from 26 companies across the continent.



Kapoor with the award

The magazine had last year won the Asia Media Award for its first 30th anniversary issue which was published in December 2005. Says Art Editor Sapna Kapoor, who designed both the issues, "It feels good when one's work is appreciated by a worldwide audience."

by Priya Verma

OBJECT OF DESIRE



Small Wonder

SONY DAV-IS10 HOME THEATRE, Rs 39,990

Five tiny speakers the size of a golf ball each, a sub-woofer and a 550-watt DVD player packs a punch for a superb home entertainment experience when connected to a television set or a music system. The control centre combines a DVD/CD/MP3 player with a surround processor and an FM/AM tuner. The DVD unit features touch sensitive controls that illuminate and disappear on touch. All this is wireless, saving the sore sight of wires hanging loose or having to be tucked away.



Babus' New Clothes

PATNA Babus in Bihar will no longer have the luxury of wearing T-shirts and denims, thanks to a directive issued by state Chief Secretary A.K. Chaudhury. The dress code directs officers to wear shirts and trousers in light colours or the traditional dhoti-kurta. Women officers will have to wear saris or salwar kameez with a dupatta. "This will now help us establish a proper work-culture and discipline the babus," says Deputy Chief Minister Sushil Kumar Modi. by Amitabh Srivastava